Pivotum

THE DEGREE RISK INDEX · FALL 2026 EDITION · FREE SAMPLER

Is a Data Science Degree Worth It in the AI Era? The 2026 Risk Score

The free sampler — the score by track, the six factors in brief, and the honest reasons to think twice. The complete profile goes deeper.

8.2

AI EXPOSURE · ENTRY DATA ANALYST

where 10 is most at risk

Re-scored every six months. We publish where we might be wrong.

HIGHLIGHTING IS COLOR-CODED

THE FINDING EXPOSURE PROTECTION METHOD & HONESTY

Quick answer: Entry-level data analysis scores **8.2 out of 10** for AI exposure, where 10 is most at risk — one of the highest scores in this index. ML and AI engineering scores **6.0**. Data science is the field closest to the technology itself, and that has not protected it. If anything, it made it a faster target.

The short answer for parents: this is not the safe technical career it was sold as three years ago. The people *building* AI systems are reasonably protected. The much larger number of people who query databases, build dashboards and produce analyses are not, and that is where almost all the entry-level jobs are.

Data science AI risk score by role

Every career in this index is scored 1–10, where **10 is most exposed** to AI. Same six factors, same weights, applied identically to a data scientist and a paramedic.

ROLE	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVE	BAND
ML / AI engineer	5.0	5.5	**6.0**	+1.0	Moderate
Senior data scientist	5.5	6.1	**6.5**	+1.0	Moderate–High
Data engineer	6.0	6.5	**7.0**	+1.0	Moderate–High
Analytics engineer / BI developer	6.4	7.1	**7.6**	+1.2	High
Entry data analyst	6.7	7.5	**8.2**	+1.5	High

2023 and 2025 figures are reconstructed using current methodology, not archived from past editions.

How that compares: the median career in this edition scores around 5.5. Entry-level software development scores **8.1**. Licensed engineering scores **4.0**. Bedside nursing scores **2.8**.

Every track in this field moved at least a full point in three years. No other profession we score has such a uniformly fast-moving set of numbers — because unlike other fields, there is no protected core here for the movement to stop at.

Will AI replace data analysts?

It is doing a great deal of the work already, and the reason is uncomfortable: data work is exactly the shape of task these systems handle best.

AI IS TAKING	IT CAN'T TOUCH
Writing SQL and queries	Deciding what question is worth asking
Building dashboards and reports	Knowing the data is wrong before the model does
Exploratory analysis and summary stats	Understanding why the business cares
Data cleaning and transformation	Judgment when the result is surprising
Standard model fitting and tuning	Owning a recommendation that costs money
Documentation and analysis write-ups	Knowing what *shouldn't* be automated

Inputs arrive as structured data. Outputs are code, charts and text. There is no physical component, no licensing requirement, and no regulatory body standing between the work and its automation.

Why does data science score so high? The six factors

How entry-level data analysis rates against each. Ratings are 0–10 on each factor's own terms.

FACTOR	RATING	EFFECT ON RISK
How much of this job can AI already do?	9.0	↑ severe exposure
How hard will it be to land that first job?	8.5	↑ severe exposure
Does it have to be done in person, with your hands?	1.0	↓ none
Does someone need a human they can trust and hold responsible?	4.0	↓ weak
Does the law require a licensed human?	1.0	↓ none
How often does the job hit genuinely new, high-stakes situations?	4.0	↓ weak

ONE FACTOR, WORKED THROUGH IN FULL

So you can see what the analysis actually looks like.

How much of this job can AI already do? — rated 9.0, and proximity to the technology offers no protection at all

There is an intuition worth dismantling here, because a lot of families are relying on it: that working *with* AI must be safer than working alongside it. That people who understand these systems will be the last displaced by them.

The index says otherwise, and the reason is structural rather than ironic.

Exposure is determined by the shape of the work, not by the subject matter. Our framework asks whether a task takes structured inputs, produces text or code as output, requires no physical presence, involves no licensed accountability, and repeats recognizable patterns. Data analysis answers yes to every one — which is precisely what makes it a field where AI is useful, and precisely what makes it automatable.

A data analyst is not protected by understanding AI, any more than a copywriter is protected by understanding language.

What actually separates a 6.0 from an 8.2 inside this field is the same thing that separates tracks everywhere else: judgment and accountability.

An ML engineer designing a system that will make decisions at scale rates 8.0 on novelty, because the failure modes are unprecedented and expensive. A senior data scientist telling an executive their strategy is unsupported by the data carries accountability that attaches to a person. An entry analyst producing a requested dashboard carries neither, and rates 4.0 on both.

The general lesson: being close to a technology is not the same as being protected from it. Ask what shape the work is — where the inputs come from, whether a human must answer for the output — not what the work is *about*.

Which data roles are safest from AI?

Ranked by exposure, safest first:

1. **ML / AI engineer — 6.0.** Building systems rather than using them, with genuinely novel failure modes. 2. **Senior data scientist — 6.5.** Framing problems and carrying recommendations, rather than answering questions. 3. **Data engineer — 7.0.** Infrastructure work with real complexity, though heavily automatable pipelines. 4. **Analytics engineer / BI — 7.6.** Dashboard and reporting work, close to a definitional automation target. 5. **Entry data analyst — 8.2.** The most exposed track, and the traditional entry route.

Note that nothing in this field scores below 6.0. Data science has no physical component, no licensure and no structural protection of any kind. The entire range is set by seniority.

Is a data science degree still worth it in 2026?

It depends heavily on which end of the field it points at, and most programs point at the exposed end.

The versions that hold up:

- **Genuine engineering depth** — building systems rather than analyzing outputs. ML engineering and data infrastructure remain scarcer skills than analysis.
- **Domain pairing** — data science plus healthcare, finance, energy or biology. The domain knowledge is the protection, and it is what lets someone know when a result is wrong.
- **Statistical rigor rather than tooling** — understanding why a method is appropriate, which is what survives when running the method becomes free.

The version that does not: a program teaching Python, SQL, dashboarding and standard model fitting, pointed at an analyst job. That is training for the most automated work in the field.

Worth asking any program: what proportion of your graduates are in engineering or research roles versus analyst roles, and how has that shifted in three years?

Common questions

Will AI replace data scientists? It is displacing a large share of routine analysis already. Senior roles that frame problems and carry recommendations are holding better, but nothing in this field has structural protection.

Is data science still a good career? At the engineering and senior end, reasonably — around 6.0 to 6.5. The entry tier at 8.2 is among the most exposed work we score.

Is data science safer than software engineering? Marginally at entry — 8.2 against 8.1, effectively identical. Both fields are healthy at the top and severely compressed at the bottom.

What data jobs are safest from AI? ML and AI engineering at 6.0, then senior data science at 6.5. Both depend on judgment about novel systems rather than on producing analysis.

Should my child study data science or statistics? Statistical depth tends to travel better than tooling. Knowing why a method applies survives the automation of running it.

Related careers

- Computer science — 8.1 entry-level, 5.4 senior. Free to read in full.
- Cybersecurity — 7.4 SOC analyst, 5.0 incident response
- Engineering — 4.0 licensed and site-based, 6.3 desk and CAD
- Finance — 8.0 entry analyst, 4.6 advisory
- Business and management — 7.6 analyst, 4.9 leadership

What's in the data science Career Value Guide

This sampler tells you where data science stands. The full Career Value Guide tells you what to do about it.

	SAMPLER	CAREER VALUE GUIDE
Verdict, all role scores, 3-year trend	✓	✓
Six-factor ratings	✓	✓
Reasoning behind every factor rating	one example	✓
How durable each protection is		✓
The entry-path problem in detail — and what still works as a route in		✓
The honest downsides — oversupply, tooling churn, title inflation		✓
What's genuinely good about it — and who this work suits		✓
The AI-native advantage — how to prepare, and why this cohort has an opening		✓
Domain pairings that work		✓
Where the degree leads later		✓
Program evaluation checklist — engineering depth, statistical rigor, placement		✓
Questions to ask a program — plus red flags		✓
Sourced further reading		✓
Discussion questions for parent and student		✓
A short version written directly to the student		✓
Technical scoring appendix		✓

GET THE CAREER VALUE GUIDE

Most families are weighing two or three careers seriously, and a few more they haven't ruled out. Pick the ones you need.

1 career	**$49**	Choose →
3 careers	**$69**	Choose →
Unlimited	**$99**	Choose →

Each Career Value Guide includes everything in the table above, plus a short version written directly to the student and the technical scoring appendix. This edition and the next are included — we re-score every six months, so what you buy stays current for a year.

Read a complete Career Value Guide free → We publish one Career Value Guide in full, openly, so you can judge the depth before buying anything. Computer science is the one to read — it's the most surprising result in the index.

Pivotum scores thirty careers against AI exposure using a fixed, published methodology, re-scored every six months. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. We publish where we might be wrong.